7

‘MAXIMUM LEADER’

HAMID KARZAI, INDIA, AND THE KABUL DURBAR

‘India has a critical interest in the survival of the Karzai regime.’

M. K. Narayanan, NSA of India (2005–10)[1]

‘Mr. Karzai is no Massoud but he can meet the current challenge even now [in 2013] if he abandons the narrow politics he has pursued since 2001.’

Vivek Katju, Indian Ambassador to Afghanistan (2002–05)[2]

‘I met [Mohammad] Mohaqiq the other day and asked him these questions that the [Karzai] government is saying that you are going off talking to the Pakistanis and so on. But I can’t tell the president [Karzai] politely that please don’t try to shoot them [Karzai’s opponents] off from our back now.’

Gautam Mukhopadhaya, India’s Ambassador to Afghanistan (2010–13)[3]

New beginnings

Two planes, one Indian and the other Pakistani, landed in Afghanistan on 21 November 2001. The massive Il-76 carrier of the Indian Air Force descended at Bagram airbase after a 17-hour flight from New Delhi (bypassing Pakistani airspace) that included two stopovers (one near Dubai and the other in Meshed, Iran). The Pakistani plane landed at the Kunduz airfield nearly 300 km north of